

Section B Option 1: Families and relationships

This option focuses on the family as a central agency of socialisation and a main transmitter of culture in contemporary society. It allows learners to explore contemporary family structures and relationships.

Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. How diverse are modern families?	The diversity of family and household types in the contemporary UK: • nuclear families • extended families • lone parent families • reconstituted families • same-sex families • non-family households Aspects of and reasons for family and household diversity in the contemporary UK, including: • trends in marriage, divorce and cohabitation • demographic changes: ○ birth-rate ○ family size ○ age at marriage ○ age of child-bearing ○ ageing population • family diversity in terms of: ○ social class ○ ethnicity ○ sexuality The ideology of the nuclear family and the theoretical debates about the role and desirability of the nuclear family in contemporary society: • functionalism • New Right • Marxism • feminism • postmodernism Debates about the extent of family diversity in the contemporary UK	also consider newer/emerging types of families and households. have an overview of trends over the last 30 years and consider the key reasons for these changes. Detailed knowledge of statistics on marriage, divorce and demographic changes is not required. consider issues of consensus versus conflict, social order and control in relation to theoretical views of the role of the family in contemporary society. A theoretical approach to considering the extent of family diversity should be taken.

Key questions	Content	Learners should:
2. To what extent are roles and relationships within families and households changing?	Roles and relationships between partners and how they are changing, including issues of power Roles and relationships between parents and children and how they are changing, including issues of power	consider a range of issues including the domestic division of labour and the 'dark side' of the family. A theoretical approach should be taken, applying functionalist, Marxist and feminist approaches. consider issues such as the growth of the child-centred family and the extension of childhood. consider the impact of the ageing population on the relationship between grandparents, parents and children. A theoretical approach should be taken, applying feminist approaches.